

5.1 Threats To WLANs

WLANs are vulnerable in various ways, and all the vulnerabilities can be classified into two types:

1. Unauthorised Access Threats
2. Denial of Authorised Access

The first is perhaps the most deadly, as this involves threats from hackers and viruses, in an attempt to get into your network and access your data. The second type is more or less like a Denial of Service (DoS) attack, where functionality of your network may be affected by some other device, either intentionally or unintentionally.

Here we will focus more on threats of the first type, as they are more of a security risk and are perpetrated by malicious users or software.

Default SSIDs

Every wireless access point manufacturer has known and well publicised Service Set Identifiers (SSIDs). All access points ship with their default SSIDs, which a user is expected to change when they set up their WLAN. Quite often, home users set up their WLAN by powering up everything, setting the type of connection to ad-hoc, which is default, and then are overjoyed by the fact that a connection is established immediately. There are no more checks done, and the network is left the way it is, for fear of changing a setting and finding that clients cannot connect. This is perhaps the most common mistake that people make, and leave their WLAN open for absolutely anyone to access.

The very first thing you need to do when configuring your access point is to change the SSID to something only authorised users of your WLAN will know.